



By the time you reach around 36 weeks of pregnancy, the prospect of **meeting your baby is tantalizingly close**. Your doctor will begin to note how she is positioned in your uterus, whether or not her **head is engaged**, and find out your preferences for your labor. Your body could also start to give you signs that your baby will soon be here.

Before labor begins

Time and space

During the last four weeks of your pregnancy, your baby grows rapidly—at a rate of about 8 oz (225 g) per week. The space within your uterus becomes restricted and you may feel that your baby is now squirming around rather than kicking. Keep note of the movements, and if your baby “sleeps” for longer than you would expect, or her movements are weaker or less frequent than is normal for her, call the doctor immediately. Your doctor will pay special attention to the size of your belly over these last few weeks, to check whether your baby has plenty of amniotic fluid surrounding her and to make final predictions on the baby’s size at birth.

The doctor will also figure out, by palpating your abdomen, what position your baby is in. The presses may seem firm and even cause you discomfort at this stage, but don’t worry since they don’t harm your baby. Your doctor may be trying to nudge her into a better position, or to establish whether or not her head has engaged (see p.202), and if it has, how deeply engaged it is.

Talking about labor

During these last few weeks, you’ll find that conversations with your doctor will turn to labor. You’ll have the opportunity to go over your birth plan (see p.88-89),

and to raise any remaining questions. If your baby is in a breech position, or positioned across your abdomen, your doctor will talk through the implications for your labor and you’ll be encouraged to discuss these with your birth partner. Remember that labor is a constantly evolving situation, so the more information you can gather now, the more confident you’ll be about any decision you might have to make while you’re in the delivery room.

Watching and waiting

Many women spend the last few weeks of their pregnancy eagerly watching for signs that labor might be imminent and even trying myriad old wives’ tales to get the process started. Your remarkable, pregnant body is responsive to all sorts of chemical changes right now—and these can have quite surprising effects on your behavior, mood, and well-being. Try to keep yourself distracted—engage in nonstrenuous activities that require your concentration. Read the book that you’ve been meaning to try; teach yourself to knit, sew, or crochet; plant some herbs in pots; spend an afternoon watching movies. Don’t overexert yourself, but do try to keep busy and keep your mind off the looming question of “When?” And ignore all comments in the vein of “Still no sign, then?” Just smile and change the subject.